

# Widen Your View

**After last year, the onslaught of cheaper and (sometimes) better LCDs continues. We've tested 33 of them, ranging from 17 to 24 inches of prime real estate. Take your pick...**

**Michael Browne**

After last year's flat panel fiasco and the fact that nobody was willing to send us CRTs to test, we'd thought things couldn't get any better and the time of the LCD was now... err... then! If you're wondering what all the hullabaloo is about, imagine a 19-inch widescreen LCD monitor that costs a mere Rs 14,000. Wouldn't that be enough to get everybody waiting in turn for LCDs to become more affordable salivating in anticipation? Now flash forward to this year—we've got 22-inch widescreen LCDs available for well below 14,000, with 19-inch LCDs now sitting pretty at below the 10,000 rupee mark. That's what we call *depreciation*.

If anything, the focus has shifted to the bigger panels. Previously, any LCD larger than 19 inches were rarely in stock, and orders had to be placed. As per your beloved Agent 001's last

report 22-inch panels were well and truly in stock. This focus shift is seen from manufacturers as well. You can always tell when there's a slight emphasis towards a particular product or category. This year we saw a lot of mediocre build quality in the 19-inch category. Designs were simple, nothing inspiring, ditto with the quality of materials. The 22-inch panels were another matter entirely—and this difference is not just a function of a costlier product.

Just like last year, we could only get a single 24-inch monitor for this test—it seems their time hasn't come yet.

Another very noticeable change is the rise in popularity of widescreens—especially when one crosses the 19-inch mark. Going widescreen today makes even more sense than it did last year, with most multimedia content including games supporting widescreen resolutions natively.

Sadly, the scene for *good* panels hasn't changed much. The bulk of the LCDs out there are still based on colour and contrast deficient TN (Twisted Nematic) panels. Although there were a couple of MVA (Multi-domain Vertical Alignment) panels, and a single S-IPS (Super In-Plane Switching) panel, the prices of these are significantly higher than the regular TN panels. There also exists a large difference between the prices of 24- and 22-inch monitors, making the 22-inch a superb value for money buy. Similarly, buying a 17-inch minnow makes very little sense, unless you absolutely cannot afford to spend more.

In case you're feeling a little stingy just watch a 17- and 19-inch screen in action side by side—or better still, a 17- and 22-inch. We guarantee that your wallet will open just a little bit more to gobble up one size larger than what you originally intended to splurge on.



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